

WHAT KIND OF MAN?

Father was sparse, Spartan, serious with a weird sense of humor linked to plays on words. He loved puns and referred to anyone else's pun as, "two-thirds of a pun, or PU!" When I was a child, my friends were all scared to death of him because he had an unintentional cold stare that pierced right through you. If you didn't know him well, he scared you to death—dark hair, dark complexion, not big (in fact, almost gaunt), but scary looking, and often dressed in dark clothes. Had he been twenty years younger and seventy-five years earlier, he would have looked a bit like the archetypal image of the thin, dark-haired, dark-dressed, bad-guy gunslinger in westerns. You could fantasize him saying, "Just one move and I'll plug you." But he didn't "plug" anyone. He wasn't mean. He just looked mean. He didn't have to say a word. Still, children tip-toed around him and scooted fast to avoid him. Again, he wasn't mean, but he wasn't warm and fuzzy either; and he never, ever praised anyone except my oldest brother, whom he adored from birth. Fact is, I've always known my father held me in high regard, maybe higher regard than almost anyone he ever interacted with, even if he displayed it in strange ways and often not at all. Often not at all. For example, except once when I was sixteen that I recall very, very distinctly, he never, ever praised me directly about anything at all until I was well into my forties. It bothered me when I was young, but I came to accept it. That was who he was. He just wasn't the praising kind. He would tell others how proud he was of me, almost bragging, and I'd hear it from them; but he could never tell me. He later told me he regretted that but hadn't known how to deal with it. This type of communication was difficult for my father.

Let me help you put that in perspective by describing a part of his career. Decades before a world of computer screening, he had a methodology he employed for finding new ideas for new stocks. He let it be known that any young investment man could set an appointment to meet him just once and talk investments. Usually he would never see the man again. But if he thought the person unusually capable, he would see him repeatedly and offer to swap ideas over time. He let the other guy know what he was interested in and vice versa; and then over time if they saw something of